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FROM PROPHECY TO MYSTICISM: BONAVENTURE'S ESCHATOLOGY IN LIGHT OF JOACHIM OF FIORE

BY ILIA DELIO

INTRODUCTION

In the Middle Ages, the destiny of the historical process was a subject of intense thought, fueled by an overarching notion of historical change and the impending final age. Of the many theologians who contributed to this discussion none stands out in more colorful form than the Cistercian abbot, Joachim of Fiore (1135–1202).¹ Joachim made his mark by describing history as a process of patterns unfolding according to the relationships of the Trinity. For Joachim, history was an ongoing work of the living God, and he sought to elucidate the innermost mystery of the trinitarian relationships in the working-out of history. The whole process of history, he maintained, was progressing toward a higher spiritual level that would be characterized by the image of the mystical body of Christ in the final age, an age that he held would take place in this world. Although Bonaventure dismissed Joachim early in his academic career as ignorant and *simplex*,² his rise to minister general in an order divided by radical Joachimism may have influenced his view of the abbot's theology.³ E. Randolph

¹Joachim of Fiore, also referred to as the "Calabrian abbot," was a Cistercian abbot of a monastery in Corazzo in the early 1180s. Around 1190, he left the Cistercian order and founded his own monastery at San Giovanni in Fiore in the alpine sila plateau of Calabria. For the details of his life, see Bernard McGinn, *The Calabrian Abbot: Joachim of Fiore in the History of Western Thought* (New York, 1985), 3–37; Herbert Grundmann, *Neue Forschungen über Joachim von Fiore* (Marburg, 1950), 31–64.

²I *Sent.* d. 5, a. 2, q. 2, dub. 4 (I, 121). "Et ideo ignoranter Ioachim reprehendit Magistrum, et quia, cum esset simplex, non est reveritus Magistrum, ideo iusto Dei iudicio damnatus fuit libellus eius in Lateranensi Concilio, et positio Magistri approbata." The critical edition of Bonaventure's works used in this study is the *Opera Omnia*, ed. PP. Collegii S. Bonaventurae, 10 vols. (Quaracchi, 1882–1902). Latin texts are indicated by volume and page number in parentheses.

The following abbreviations are used throughout the text: *Sent.* = Commentary on the *Sentences*; *Brev.* = *Breviloquium*; *Hex.* = *Hexaëmeron*; *De plant. par.* = *Tractatus de plantatione paradisi*; *Itin.* = *Itinerarium mentis in Deum*; *LM* = *Legenda maior*; *Lig. vit.* = *Lignum vitae*.

³Joachimism became an issue in the dispute between the Franciscans and the secular masters at the University of Paris when Gerard of Borgo San Donnino published his *Liber introductorius in evangelium aeternum*, which the secular master, William of St. Amour, described as evidence that the mendicants were purveyors of heresy. The relationship between Gerard and

Daniel has shown that Bonaventure borrowed one of Joachim's patterns of history to define his eschatology more clearly in terms of Christocentricity. Like Joachim, Bonaventure held that the final age would take place in this world, and would be characterized by mystical peace. Potential Joachimist influence may also be detected in Bonaventure's *Legenda maior*.⁴

While Bonaventure may have been indebted to Joachim, he was not overly dependent on him. Rather, Joachim's theology of history enabled Bonaventure to elucidate a distinctly Franciscan eschatology closer to his own christocentric position, particularly with respect to the final age. The difference between the two eschatologies is not easy to determine; it is apparent, however, when Bonaventure's eschatology is considered in light of mystical union. This idea arises from the last chapter of his *Itinerarium mentis in Deum*, where union with the crucified Christ is described as the path to mystical peace. The thesis of this paper is that mystical union ultimately distinguishes Bonaventure's eschatology from Joachim's. Although Christocentricity marks Bonaventure's theology of history, it is mystical union that more clearly defines his eschatology as decisively Franciscan, the model of which is none other than the stigmatized Francis.

THE PROPHETIC VISION OF JOACHIM

Few people in history have stimulated as much interest in the eschatological destiny of the world as Joachim of Fiore. A man endowed with *sapientia et intelligentia*, Joachim's understanding of history deeply influenced later medieval thought. The zealous pursuit of his ideals caused him to leave his monastery at Casamari and to found his own order of San Giovanni de Fiore. The writings of this Calabrian abbot have been studiously brought to light in this century, largely through the efforts of Marjorie Reeves and her colleagues. According to Reeves, Joachim's vision of history was not entirely new since, from the time of Augustine, the subject of millennialism and the meaning of history were readily discussed.⁵ While Augustine's theology of history dominated the Middle Ages, there were indications in the twelfth century of a new interest in the movement of history, its progress, and its conclusion, provoked by an awareness of change. Reeves, in her discussion of Joachim's originality, provides a thorough

his brother, John of Parma, minister general from 1247 to 1257, is not entirely clear but John was somehow linked with his radical brother. He resigned as minister in 1257 and nominated Bonaventure as his successor. For a brief summary of the controversy, see E. Randolph Daniel, "St. Bonaventure: Defender of Franciscan Eschatology," in S. *Bonaventura 1274-1974*, ed. Jacques Bougerol, 4 vols. (Grottaferatta, 1974), 4:797-98; John Moorman, *A History of the Franciscan Order* (Oxford, 1968), 124-31.

⁴Richard K. Emmerson and Ronald B. Herzman, *The Apocalyptic Imagination in Medieval Literature* (Philadelphia, 1992), 34-75.

⁵Marjorie Reeves, "The Originality and Influence of Joachim of Fiore," *Traditio* 36 (1980): 271-88.

background on medieval theories of history prior to Joachim, stating, "the ground was well tilled for him."⁶ Although Joachim did not in fact break new ground in the twelfth century, he did spearhead a new vision that decisively broke with the Augustinian tradition and emphasized the full illumination of the Spirit yet to come. Joachim appropriated Augustine's earlier pattern of seven ages corresponding to the seven days of creation; however, while Augustine came to believe that the final age would take place beyond history, Joachim held that the seventh or final age would take place in this world, after the tribulation of the Antichrist and before the last judgment.⁷ The seventh age, he argued, was virtually contemporaneous with the sixth age. While the sixth age corresponded to the passion of Christ, the seventh age corresponded to contemplative peace. Joachim's unique contribution, according to Reeves, was his first affirmation of a coming major turning point within history that would usher in a blessed and charismatic time of peace.⁸ This was a radical departure from the Augustinian notion of the consummation of the seventh age in eternity.

Joachim had, in Reeves's term, a "kaleidoscopic imagination" and saw things in patterns. His most original thought lay in his belief that the innermost mystery of inter-personal relationships in the Trinity is reflected in the working out of history.⁹ He envisioned the movement of history as a dynamic process toward a new stage, illustrated by his various figures of flowering trees.¹⁰ These arboreal images imaginatively illustrated the periods of history as not merely succeeding one another in time but as having, like the persons of the Trinity, inner relations that give history an organic and dynamic character of its own. The new stage that he envisioned was to be a logical climax of the whole historical process; because it was still part of time, however, it did not embody final perfection. Joachim's illustrations of trees signified that the cosmos and history do not change or condition God, but rather that history must adopt the structure it does

⁶Ibid., 283. The notion of a progressive movement of history was discussed by Rupert of Deutz, Anselm of Havelberg, Honorius of Autun, and Gerhoh of Reichersberg. See Peter Clasen, "Res Gestae, Universal History, Apocalypse: Visions of Past and Future," in *Renaissance and Renewal in the Twelfth Century*, ed. Robert L. Benson and Giles Constable (Cambridge, 1982), 404–8.

⁷Reeves, "Originality," 274–76; eadem, *Joachim of Fiore and the Prophetic Future* (New York, 1977), 8. On Augustine's Pattern of Seven Ages see *De Genesi contra Manichaeos* 1.23 (PL 34.190–93).

⁸Reeves, "Originality," 277–85; E. Randolph Daniel, "Abbot Joachim of Fiore: The *De Ultimis Tribulationibus*," in *Essays in Honour of Marjorie Reeves*, ed. Anne Williams (Harlow, 1980), 170; Robert Lerner, "Medieval Return to the Thousand-Year Sabbath," in *The Apocalypse in the Middle Ages*, ed. Richard K. Emmerson and Bernard McGinn (Ithaca, 1992), 51–71.

⁹Reeves, "Originality," 293.

¹⁰For the study on Joachim's arboreal figures, see Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore* (Oxford, 1972), 1–19.

precisely because God, its Creator, is three persons. As Reeves states, “in the image of the tree, Joachim found the perfect expression of the Trinity conceived at work in all of history.”¹¹

Joachim describes the process of history in patterns of twos and threes. The pattern of threes corresponds to the persons of the Trinity and is designated as the *prima diffinitio*.¹² In the *prima diffinitio* the first *status*, that of the Father, belongs to the married. The second *status*, which is common to both the Son and the Holy Spirit, belongs to the clergy and monks. The third *status*, that of the Holy Spirit, belongs to monks. The three ages are, therefore, the historical unfolding of the relationships among the married, the clergy, and the monks, who all embody the spiritual bond of love. According to Joachim, the religious orders in the church evolve progressively toward the final goal. This evolution is nothing less than the historical realization among the orders of the relationships among the persons of the Trinity. The goal is the actualization of a society in which the orders mirror the life of the Trinity itself.¹³ Scholars have interpreted this scheme as one in which Christ functions as the turning point in a history in which the age of the Son is supplanted by the age of the Spirit.¹⁴ While the existence of a distinct age of the Holy Spirit is a logical outcome of the trinitarian pattern of history, this interpretation has been a controverted issue among Joachimite scholars.¹⁵ Some have claimed that the third status or final age, the age of the Spirit, supplants the age of the Son. Such an interpretation, however, minimizes Joachim’s Christology. According to Daniel, Joachim did not envision the third *status* as an exclusive age of monks. Rather, he believed that God

¹¹Marjorie Reeves, “The Liber Figurarum of Joachim of Fiore,” in *Medieval and Renaissance Studies*, ed. Richard Hunt and Raymond Klibansky (London, 1950), 182.

¹²On Joachim’s patterns, see E. Randolph Daniel, “Joachim of Fiore: Patterns of History in the Apocalypse,” in *Apocalypse in the Middle Ages*, 72–88.

¹³E. Randolph Daniel, “The Double Procession of the Holy Spirit in Joachim of Fiore’s Understanding of History,” *Speculum* 55 (1980): 474.

¹⁴Marjorie Reeves, “Dante and the Prophetic View of History,” in *The World of Dante: Essays on Dante and His Times*, ed. Cecil Grayson (Oxford, 1980), 54; Antonio Crocco, *Gioacchino da Fiore e il Gioachimismo* (Naples, 1976), 91–114; Joseph Ratzinger, *The Theology of History in St. Bonaventure*, trans. Zachary Hayes (Chicago, 1971), 108–18.

¹⁵Morton Bloomfield, “Joachim of Flora: A Critical Survey of His Canon, Teachings, Sources, Biography and Influences,” in *Joachim of Fiore in Christian Thought*, ed. Delno C. West (New York, 1975) 1: 260–71; Crocco, *Gioacchino da Fiore*, 91–114; Bernard McGinn, “The Abbot and the Doctors: Scholastic Reactions to the Radical Eschatology of Joachim of Fiore,” *Church History* 40 (1971): 30–47. McGinn sums up the controversy by saying (34), “the relationship of the third age to the second is the center of the most heated debates over just how radical Joachim’s eschatology really is. Those who wish to preserve his fundamental orthodoxy claim that by the third age is meant nothing more than the purified church with its institutions and sacraments intact, in other words, Joachim is just another orthodox reformer. Other scholars see the third age as effecting serious changes in the institutions of the present church (especially with regard to the papacy, the sacraments, and the supremacy of the clerical order), and thus challenging the centrality of Christ in the divine scheme of salvation.”

viewed the three orders as one body of believers made of flesh, blood, and the breath of life.¹⁶ Basing his ideas on Paul's letter to the Ephesians (4:13), Joachim states that the three orders must evolve until they become the image and likeness of the Trinity, so that at last all shall come together in the unity of the faith, into mature manhood according to the measure of the fullness of Christ.¹⁷ The goal of Joachim's *prima diffinitio* is to build up the body of Christ — that is, to realize the *pleroma*.¹⁸ This is achieved only in the third *status*, which is the *status* of the fullness of Christ (*plenitudo Christi*). Joachim is able to ascribe the third *status* to the Holy Spirit, and at the same time to envision it as the realization of the mystical body of Christ, because the third *status* is the historical expression of the procession of the Holy Spirit from the Son. Since the *pleroma* of the third *status* is the unity of the diverse, in other words, Joachim never envisioned the monks alone without the other two orders.¹⁹

The essence of Joachim's thought about the nature of history, however, lay not in a single pattern of threes but in two coexisting patterns, as shown in his *Liber figurarum*. In his *secunda diffinitio*, history is divided into two *tempora*, the Old Testament and the New Testament, each with seven periods. The seventh age of New Testament time corresponds to the dominance of *virī spirituales* and the age of peace.²⁰ Christ stands at the center of the two *tempora*, the first being from Adam to Christ, the second from Christ to the end of history. The first *tempus* begins with Adam and reaches its maturity with Jacob. The *initiatio* of the second *tempus* commences with Josiah, thus overlapping with the final phase of the first *tempus*. The *fructificatio* of the second *tempus* begins with Christ, and this *tempus* will endure until the end of history itself. It is parallel chronologically to the early Augustine's sixth *aetas*, the period between the coming of Christ in humility and his final coming in glory. Whereas in the *prima diffinitio* Joachim worked out the relationship among the three orders, in the two *tempora* of the *secunda diffinitio* he is concerned with the relationship between two

¹⁶ Joachim of Fiore, *Liber de concordia novi ac veteris testamenti* (Venice, 1519; repr. Frankfurt a. M., 1964), bk. 2, tr. 1, ch. 8, fol. 9va. "Ita enim existimanda est apud deum universa multitudo credentium ac si unus homo qui constat ex carne et sanguine et spiraculo vite."

¹⁷ Ibid.

¹⁸ Daniel, "Double Procession," 478.

¹⁹ Ibid., 476.

²⁰ Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, *Figurae* (n. 10 above), 7–9. On the *virī spirituales*, see Marjorie Reeves, *The Influence of Prophecy in the Middle Ages* (Oxford, 1969), 175–83; eadem, *Joachim and the Prophetic Future* (n. 7 above), 29–58; Bernard McGinn, "Apocalyptic Traditions and Spiritual Identity in Thirteenth-Century Religious Life," in *The Spirituality of Western Christendom 2: The Roots of the Modern Christian Tradition*, ed. E. Rozanne Elder (Kalamazoo, 1984), 1–26; Deborah Workman, "The Spirit Clothed in Flesh" (Ph.D. dissertation, Kent State University, 1986), 212–28; cf. Ratzinger (*Theology of History*, 41–42), who notes that Joachim designated the final order of the seventh age as *virī spirituales* as well as *ecclesia contemplativa*, *ecclesia contemplantium*, and *ordo contemplantium*.

peoples, the Jews and the Gentiles. The key element in the *secunda diffinitio* is the *viri spirituales*, who originate from both groups. Joachim equates these *viri spirituales* with monks. Thus, during the time of the Old Testament, the *viri spirituales* include Elijah, Elisha, and the sons of the prophets; in the Gentile *tempus*, these spiritual people include both Benedictines and monks of the Greek tradition.²¹

The spiritual aim of the *secunda diffinitio* is even clearer when the two *tempora* are examined as expressions of the double procession of the Holy Spirit. The symbol of the *secunda diffinitio* is the letter omega “in which one rod (*virgula*) proceeds from the middle of two.” This represents the double procession of the Holy Spirit from the Father and the Son. The emergence of the *viri spirituales* with Elijah in the Old Testament *tempus* and with the Benedictine monks in the New Testament period, as well as the parallel development of *spirituales intellectus*, are the manifestation in history of the double procession of the Holy Spirit. The convergence of the two sides of the omega into the ascending middle rod suggests strongly that Joachim envisioned history moving toward a goal in which the *viri spirituales* and the *spirituales intellectus* will be predominant. He expected the full realization of the activities of these groups to be attained only in the final period of rest and contemplation. In the *secunda diffinitio*, the whole thrust of history surges toward this goal. Joachim did not envision a new gospel or a third spiritual testament; rather, he believed Christ would send the Holy Spirit to accomplish what he had begun but could not finish in his earthly ministry. As the Father had sent the Spirit in the first *tempus*, so Christ would send him in the second, so that, as the one who is sent by two, he could complete the self-revelation of God within history.²²

Daniel has suggested that, on the historical level, the two *diffinitiones* are complementary.²³ In both, history is described in terms of trinitarian patterns, whereby emphasis is placed on the double procession of the Holy Spirit from the Father and the Son. Within the Trinity, the generation of the Son by the Father and the procession of the Spirit from the Father and the Son are simultaneous and eternal. Within history, however, the generation of the Son from the Father and the procession of the Spirit from the Father are temporally prior to the mission of the Holy Spirit from the Son. Thus the historical realization of the Trinity is not entirely analogous to the inner life of the Trinity itself. It is this setting apart of the procession of the Spirit from the generation of the Son that makes both *diffinitiones* significant, pointing toward the future full realization of the body of Christ and the attainment of liberty and contemplation. The complementarity of the two *diffinitiones* is related to the ultimate goal of

²¹ Reeves, *Influence of Prophecy*, 18–20.

²² Daniel, “Double Procession,” 480.

²³ *Ibid.*, 481.

history, the *plenitudo Christi*; the fullness of the mystical body of Christ is to be realized in a sabbath of holy rest and contemplation.²⁴

BONAVENTURE'S FRANCISCAN ESCHATOLOGY

Joachim's theology of history, with its integral relation to the inner life of the Trinity, met with mixed reactions in the Middle Ages. Thomas Aquinas wrote off his prophecies as "conjectures"; Dante placed him in the *Paradiso*; Bonaventure, who dismissed Joachim as ignorant and *simplex* in his first book of the *Sentences* was eventually influenced by him. Daniel shows that in his *Hexaëmeron*, Bonaventure makes a definite break with the Augustinian interpretation of history and develops a new theology of the development of time that finds its closest affinity with Joachim's *secunda diffinitio*.²⁵

The foundation of Bonaventure's theology of history rests on two principal figures in the Middle Ages: Augustine and Joachim of Fiore. Bonaventure structures the historical process according to the early Augustinian scheme of six ages, corresponding to the six days of creation.²⁶ The seventh age runs alongside the sixth (*septima aetas currit cum sexta*), and, for Augustine, is consummated in eternity.²⁷ For Bonaventure, the whole process of history is oriented to and centered on the Incarnation. Following the scheme of the six ages, he states that Christ came in the sixth age as restorer because humankind was created on the sixth day and thus the work of restoration should correspond to the work of the creation: "the first principle acting as restorer brought about the final completion of the universe."²⁸ He states that the whole course of history is oriented to its consummation in Christ since Christ is the center of Scripture, time, and history.²⁹

²⁴ *Ibid.*, 483.

²⁵ E. Randolph Daniel, "St. Bonaventure's Debt to Joachim," in *Medievalia et Humanistica*, ed. Paul Maurice Colgan (Totowa, 1982), 61–74.

²⁶ *Brev. prol.*, 2 (V, 203). In the *Breviloquium* Bonaventure defines the ages of history as follows: "The first from Adam to Noe, the second from Noe to Abraham, the third from Abraham to David, the fourth from David to the Babylonian exile, the fifth from the exile to Christ, the sixth from Christ to the end of the world; while the seventh, running concurrently with the sixth, begins with the placing of Christ in the tomb, and shall last until the universal resurrection." Trans. José de Vinck, *St. Bonaventure: The Breviloquium* (Paterson, N.J., 1963), 9. Bonaventure states at the end of this paragraph: "quando incipiet resurrectionis octava," that is, "when the eighth age of resurrection will begin." De Vinck omits this phrase from his translation.

²⁷ Augustine *De Genesi contra Manichaeos* 1.23 (n. 7 above). For a summary of Augustine's eschatology see Daniel, "Defender of Franciscan Eschatology" (n. 3 above), 795–96; cf. Reeves ("Originality of Joachim," 273) who notes Augustine's ambiguity with regard to the seventh age as a symbol of historical climax. Augustine distinguished the seventh age from the eighth age of eternity without making the seventh age a distinct age of history, although his thought later changed in this regard.

²⁸ *Brev.* 4, 4 (V, 244). Trans. De Vinck, *Breviloquium*, 154.

²⁹ *Hex.* 1, 11 (V, 331). See Ratzinger, *Theology of History* (n. 14 above), 118.

In the third book of the *Sentences* he speaks of the Incarnation as the fullness of time (*plenitudo temporis*) because it is the fullness of nature, grace, and glory.³⁰

Bonaventure's theology of history, with its stamp of Augustinian and Joachimite thought, can be understood within the framework of the *Itinerarium mentis in Deum*. Daniel has noted that the *Itinerarium*, with its six stages leading to the seventh stage of ecstatic peace, is essentially a commentary on the theology of history described in Bonaventure's *Collationes in Hexaëmeron*, although the *Itinerarium* predates the *Hexaëmeron* by about fourteen years.³¹ For Bonaventure, as in the earlier Christian Platonist tradition, the soul is a microcosm of the world. As he states in the *Hexaëmeron*: "the soul is great, the whole universe may be described in it,"³² and again, "the soul has in itself what the church has in many."³³ The soul and the world are ordered to each other because they are ordered to Christ the center.³⁴ In this respect, the *Itinerarium* undergirds a microcosm-macrocosm relationship between the soul's journey into God and the destiny of history. In the *Itinerarium*, the five stages preceding the sixth stage of the mystery of Christ progress from the outer world of vestiges to the inner world of the soul, where Christ is center. The goal of the *viator* is union with God, but in order to make the mystical ascent, the soul must be purified, illuminated, and perfected, and thus conformed to Christ. The cherubim, symbolizing the knowledge of God, overshadow the mercy seat, which is Christ. As the soul approaches the sixth stage, it apprehends the mystery of the Trinity in Christ. It must rise beyond this knowledge and above itself to attain the level of ecstatic union. Ecstasy is the summit of love, transcending knowledge. It marks the seventh stage of the soul's journey, whereby the soul, in union with Christ, passes over to the Father and to ecstatic peace.

As the six wings of the seraph correspond to the six levels of illumination that lead to the seventh stage of mystical peace, so too, history follows a sixfold course that is to terminate in a seventh age of mystical peace.³⁵ The five historical ages that precede the sixth age of Christ progress from the time before the law (*tempus ante legem*) to the time under the law (*sub lege*), to the time under grace (*sub gratia*), thus moving from historical events that prefigure Christ to the announcement of Christ and of the coming of the age of fulfillment.³⁶ As the

³⁰III *Sent.* q. 3, d. 1, dub. (III, 33). "Dicendum, quod est plenitudo naturae et plenitudo gratiae et plenitudo gloriae."

³¹Daniel, "Defender of Franciscan Eschatology," 799–800.

³²*Hex.* 22, 24 (V, 441). For a discussion on the notion of the microcosm in Bonaventure's theology see James McEvoy, "Microcosm and Macrocosm in the Writings of St. Bonaventure," in *S. Bonaventura 1274–1974*, 2:309–43.

³³*Hex.* 23, 4 (V, 445).

³⁴*Hex.* 1, 11 (V, 331).

³⁵*De plant. par.* 15 (V, 578b).

³⁶*Brev. prol.*, 2 (V, 203–4); cf. Reeves, *Influence of Prophecy* (n. 20 above), 179. In De-lorme's edition of the *Collationes in Hexaëmeron* (Florence, 1963), 160–63, a fourth time is added, that is, the time of prophecy (*tempus prophetiae*).

soul moves toward Christ, so history and time move toward their fulfillment in the sixth age, the age of the Incarnation. The time of the Incarnation is the time of the sixth age, which is the time of fullness and perfection.³⁷ As the fullness of time, Christ is the center of time, summing up in himself all that preceded him and all that would come after him:

That is why the coming of the Son of God marks the fullness of time: not because time ends with his coming, but because the hidden prophecies of all ages have been fulfilled. Had Christ come at the beginning of time, he would have come too soon; and had his coming been delayed until the very end, he would have come too late. It belonged to him as the true Savior to provide the healing-time between the time of sickness and the time of judgment, as the true Mediator, to come midway, some of his elect preceding and others following him.³⁸

In addition to the Augustinian scheme of six ages and the notion of the Incarnation at the end of time, Bonaventure adopts Joachim's *secunda diffinitio* and formulates it according to his Christocentric theology. In this scheme, the Old Testament and the New Testament each contain seven ages, and Christ stands in the center of the two testaments as the tree of life. The tree is rooted in the Old Testament and grows into maturity in the New Testament, producing the restoring fruit that is Christ.³⁹ In describing Christ, the tree of life, as the center of history, Bonaventure uses language of organic growth, seeds, fruits, and germination⁴⁰ to indicate that the historical process is dynamic; like the soul, it is on a journey to its consummation in Christ.⁴¹

Joachim, in his *Liber de concordia*, uses two cherubim to symbolize the concordance between the Old Testament and the New Testament, since the cherub symbolizes the fullness of knowledge which is found in both. Understanding of this knowledge is made possible by the Holy Spirit, who proceeds from both testaments.⁴² Similarly, in the *Itinerarium*, Bonaventure describes two cherubim who overshadow the mercy seat to indicate the two ways of contemplating God. The first cherub, signifying the Old Testament, contemplates God as being, while the second cherub, signifying the New Testament, contemplates

³⁷III *Sent.* q. 3, d. 1 dub. (III, 33). Bonaventure provides six reasons for the Incarnation as the time of fullness: "Primo, quia Deus implevit quod praeinierat. . . . Alia ratio est propter impletionem promissionis, quia ille nobis datus est . . . tertia ratio est quantum ad completionem figurarum . . . quarta ratio est propter plenitudinem gratiae quae fuit in Christo, quae fuit principium omnium plenitudinum . . . quinta ratio est propter plenitudinem generationis . . . sexta vero ratio est, quia tempus incarnationis est tempus sextae aetatis, in qua quidem est plenitudo et perfectio."

³⁸*Brev.* 4, 4 (V, 244). Trans. De Vinck, *Breviloquium*, 156.

³⁹*Hex.* 14, 6 (V, 394).

⁴⁰*Hex.* 15, 22 (V, 401).

⁴¹*Hex.* 1, 11 (V, 331); cf. Ratzinger, *Theology of History* (n. 14 above), 118.

⁴²For concordance of the two testaments see *Liber de concordia* bk. 2, tr. 1, ch. 29, fol. 18 ra–rb.

God as good. The fact that they face the mercy seat, Bonaventure states, underscores the central mystery of Christ as divine and human:

Those practiced in the third way enter with the high priest into the holy of holies where the cherubim of glory stand over the ark overshadowing the mercy seat. The first [method] looks chiefly to the Old Testament which proclaims most of all the unity of divine essence. . . . The second method looks to the new testament which determines the plurality of persons by baptizing in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. . . . The fact that they face each other with their faces turned toward the mercy seat is not without a mystical meaning, so that what our Lord said in John might be verified: "This is eternal life, that they may know you, the only true God and Jesus Christ whom you have sent" (John 17:3).⁴³

For the soul to make its mystical ascent, Bonaventure indicates, it must transcend the knowledge of God and enter into the mystery of Christ by way of love. Thus in the soul's journey there is a progression from knowledge to love. Bonaventure describes a similar scheme for the historical process. He states that Christ stands between the two testaments, symbolized by the cherubim, as the center of history and time. The movement of history to its consummation is a movement toward Christ the center. The notion of Christ the center, which forms the basis of his lectures on the *Hexaëmeron*, is described in the third *collatio*, where two cherubim gaze upon the central mystery of Christ:

The two cherubim are the two testaments whose gaze is directed upon Christ. Then he opened their minds, when they understood the Scriptures, meaning that the book of Scriptures is understood precisely through that key, the incarnate Word, the one eminently concerned with the works of restoration. For unless you understand the order and origin of restoration, you cannot understand Scripture.⁴⁴

Bonaventure holds that spiritual understanding of the Scriptures itself leads to the fulfillment of history, and he refers to this conviction in his description of *theoriae*, the inner spiritual meaning of the Scriptures, which signify the mystery of Christ. As the soul must rise above the knowledge of God and pass over in Christ to the Father to attain peace, so too, in the course of history, the seventh age is attained not by knowledge of God but by spiritual understanding. The dynamic movement of the historical process toward Christ the center is not only parallel to the soul's journey but also linked to it, since the soul is a *minor mundus*. Because the journey of the soul recapitulates the journey of the world, Bonaventure indicates that both the soul and the world are destined for spiritual marriage with Christ.

⁴³ *Itin.* 5, 1–2, 6, 4 (V, 309, 311). Trans. Ewert Cousins, *Bonaventure: The Soul's Journey Into God, The Tree of Life, The Life of St. Francis* (New York, 1978), 94–95, 106.

⁴⁴ *Hex.* 3, 11 (V, 345). Trans. José de Vinck, *St. Bonaventure: On the Six Days of Creation* (Paterson, N.J., 1966), 47–48.

THE SERAPHIC ORDER AND MYSTICAL UNION

Although Joachim did not describe a microcosm-macrocosm relationship undergirding the historical process, he did hold that that process is moving toward a sabbath age of peace in this world,⁴⁵ an idea that Bonaventure also held.⁴⁶ In his exposition of history, Joachim claimed that in the transition from the sixth age to the seventh age, God would send two religious orders that would fight against evil, undergo suffering, and emerge triumphant in the seventh age. He referred to these orders as the *virī spirituales*, symbolized by the angel of the sixth seal found in the book of Revelation (7:2).⁴⁷ Joachim claimed that the *virī spirituales* were to prepare the elect for the time of renovation in the seventh age. For Bonaventure, Francis was the true *vir spiritualis* and he described him as a "hierarchic man," one who attained the seventh age of peace.⁴⁸ In the prologue of the *Legenda maior*, he referred to Francis as the angel of the sixth seal, "having the seal of the living God," the mark of the Tau.⁴⁹ This was indicated by the fact that Francis's encounter with the Crucified was his seventh vision of the cross,⁵⁰ having received the stigmata two years before his death.⁵¹ In light of Francis's stigmata, Bonaventure perceived that the eschatological goal was destined to take place within history. Francis's entrance into the seventh age of mystical peace ushered in a new understanding of the final age in Christ.

Hans Urs von Balthasar wrote that what Joachim prophesied, Bonaventure

⁴⁵Daniel, "*De Ultimis Tribulationibus*" (n. 8 above), 170.

⁴⁶Bernard McGinn, "The Influence of St. Francis on the Theology of the High Middle Ages," in *Bonaventuriana: Miscellanea in onore di Jacques Guy Bougerol*, ed. Francisco de Asis Chavero Blanco, 2 vols. (Rome, 1988), 1:113–14; idem, "Abbot and the Doctors" (n. 15 above), 44; cf. Ratzinger (*Theology of History*, 14) who states: "Bonaventure believes in a new salvation in history within the limits of time. This is a very significant shift in the understanding of history and must be seen as the central historico-theological problem of the *Hexaëmeron*."

⁴⁷Reeves, "Originality of Joachim" (n. 5 above), 300; eadem, *Influence of Prophecy* (n. 20 above), 176; Albert Haase, "Bonaventure's *Legenda Maior*: A Redaction Critical Approach" (Ph.D. dissertation, Fordham University, 1990), 296.

⁴⁸McGinn, "Influence of Francis," 114. In a corrupted text at the end of *collatio* 16 and in a more detailed discussion in *collatio* 22, Bonaventure identifies the coming age of peace with the appearance of Francis. He also cites Apoc. 7:2 in reference to the hierarchized soul and those who are sealed with the sign of the living God (*Hex.* 23, 2–3, 14 [V, 445, 447]). The seal is also interpreted as the seal of love impressed on the contemplative soul. See *Hex.* 23, 11–14 (V, 446–47).

⁴⁹*LM* prol., 1–2 (EM, 4). The critical edition of the *Legenda maior* used is the *Legenda maior S. Francisci Assisiensis*, ed. PP. Collegii S. Bonaventurae (Quaracchi, 1941), 2–125. Since the *editio minor* is used, Latin texts are indicated by EM and page number in parentheses.

⁵⁰Reeves and Hirsch-Reich, *Figurae* (n. 10 above), 13–19. The number seven symbolizes the spirit and inner fulfillment. Joachim used a pattern of fives and sevens to illustrate the progression of history to its consummation.

⁵¹*LM* 13, 10 (EM, 114); Haase, "Bonaventure's *Legenda Maior*," 341.

saw fulfilled in Francis.⁵² Although Bonaventure perceived Francis as a *vir spiritualis*, Francis became the basis of Bonaventure's own insight, namely, that union with Christ is the key to the final age of peace. The notion of Christ as center was already contained in his commentary on the *Sentences* and in the *Breviloquium*; however, in view of the stigmata, he understood that one had to be *in union* with Christ to attain the age of peace. On the mountain of La Verna, he realized in a flash of insight that true peace is not attained unless the soul "passes over . . . through ecstatic elevations of Christian wisdom," that is, through the Crucified.⁵³ Such peace is the fruit of mystical ecstasy, the attainment of perfect love and wisdom. This is the significance of the journey symbolized by the six wings of the seraph, a movement which transcends knowledge:

If you wish to know how these things come about, ask grace not instruction, desire not understanding, the groaning of prayer not diligent reading, the Spouse not the teacher, God not man, darkness not clarity, not light but the fire that totally inflames and carries us into God by ecstatic unctions and burning affections.⁵⁴

Based on his insight, Bonaventure identifies peace with the "burning love of the Crucified,"⁵⁵ an identification not found in Joachim. He states, "no one can enter the heavenly Jerusalem by contemplation unless he or she enters the blood of the lamb as through a door," indicating that peace is the fruit of contemplation, that is, a wholehearted conformity to Christ.⁵⁶ Further he states that no one is disposed to divine contemplation unless he or she has desire, which arises from ardent prayer.⁵⁷ Bonaventure's discovery of mystical union as the key to peace provides an important foundation to his eschatology. Union with Christ is the necessary mystical element for attaining the final age, an element that is missing in Joachim's doctrine. As Morton Bloomfield states:

He [Joachim] regarded himself as an exegete or commentator inspired by the gift of intelligence. . . . There is no longing for union with God in his writings or any of the Song-of-Songs mysticism so characteristic of the Cistercians.⁵⁸

In order to express the goal of the final age as one characterized by mystical union with Christ, Bonaventure describes history in the pseudo-Dionysian terms of a hierarchical order. Just as the hierarchized soul is purified, illumined, and ultimately conformed to Christ, so too, he indicates, the same process must occur

⁵²Han Urs von Balthasar, *Studies in Theological Style: Clerical Styles*, trans. Andrew Louth et al. (San Francisco, 1984), 263.

⁵³*Itin.* prol., 3 (V, 295).

⁵⁴*Itin.* 7, 6 (V, 313). Trans. Cousins, *Bonaventure*, 115.

⁵⁵*Itin.* prol., 1–2 (V, 295).

⁵⁶*Itin.* prol., 3 (V, 295).

⁵⁷*Ibid.*

⁵⁸Bloomfield, "Critical Survey of His Canon" (n. 15 above), 42.

in history.⁵⁹ He sees a progressive development from the time of the law to the time of prophecy to the time of grace; the sixth age, the age of the Incarnation, is the age of perfection and restoration.⁶⁰ The hierarchy of the historical process corresponds to various orders of people. In the *Hexaëmeron*, he equates the three orders — laity, clergy, and monks, each assigned to a person of the Trinity — with the nine choirs of angels. In the final monastic order of the Spirit, the three suborders of contemplatives, speculatives, and ecstatics are assigned respectively to thrones, cherubim, and seraphim.⁶¹ While the cherubim, symbolizing knowledge, correspond to the mendicants, the seraphim, symbolizing love, are those who are united with God by means of ecstasy. Since this highest order of ecstatic love was attained by Francis, Bonaventure indicates that the perfection of the final age is already at hand.⁶²

Scholars have debated whether or not Francis's attainment of peace in the seraphic order was intended to be a model for mendicants alone or for the entire church. Joseph Ratzinger, basing his argument primarily on the *Hexaëmeron*, interpreted the Bonaventurian distinction between the order of cherubim and the order of seraphim as the failure of the Franciscan order to live up to its original ideal: "This final order is in no way identical with the present Order of Franciscans."⁶³ The friars were still living in the sixth age and had not attained the

⁵⁹*Hex.* 20, 1–30 (V, 425–30); *Hex.* 21, 17–33 (V, 434–36); *Hex.* 22, 1–23 (V, 437–41); Pseudo-Dionysius *De coelesti hierarchia* 3.2–3, 8.1 (PG 3.166–67); idem, *De ecclesiastica hierarchia* 5.3, 7 (PG 3.503, 507). The Pseudo-Dionysius states that the goal of hierarchy "is to enable beings to be as like as possible to God and to be at one with him" (*Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, trans. Colm Luibheid [New York, 1987], 154). It is within the framework of procession and return that Dionysius uses the categories of purification, illumination, and perfection, which Bonaventure adapts both for the soul's journey and for the historical process (*Itin.* 4, 3; *Hex.* 20, 3; 22, 16). For Dionysius, the trio of purification, illumination, and perfection underlines the progress along the path of spiritual understanding in the ascent to God. In the *Hexaëmeron*, Bonaventure transforms the notion of a cosmic hierarchy into a historical scheme so that hierarchical progress is not only by vertical dignity but also by development within history (*Hex.* 22, 16). See Ratzinger, *Theology of History* (n. 14 above), 92–94; McGinn, "Influence of St. Francis" (n. 46 above), 114.

⁶⁰*Brev.* 4, 1 (V, 241).

⁶¹*Hex.* 22, 6–23 (V, 438–41).

⁶²*Hex.* 22, 22 (V, 441). "Iste est ordo seraphicus. De isto videtur fuisse Franciscus. Et dicebat, quod etiam antequam haberet habitum, raptus fuit et inventus iuxta quandam sepem." Bonaventure is speaking here about the level of ecstasy which Francis attained and which characterizes the seraphic order. However, the word "rapture" is inserted into the text and seems to be an interpolation by the reporter of the lectures on the *Hexaëmeron* that Bonaventure delivered to the friars in Paris. It is unlikely that Bonaventure would use the term "rapture" synonymously with "ecstasy," since he held that these are two different types of experience. See *Hex.* 3, 30 (V, 348).

⁶³Ratzinger, *Theology of History*, 55. Ratzinger's position was later affirmed by McGinn ("Abbot and the Doctors," 45) who concludes: "Francis's eschatological position has been maintained, but by depriving him of the honor of founding the Franciscans!"

order to which their holy founder belonged. He claimed, therefore, that the original intuition of Francis was clearly differentiated from the institutional Franciscan order.⁶⁴ This position was challenged in 1973 by Daniel, who based his argument not only on the *Hexaëmeron* but also on the *Itinerarium*, the *Legenda maior*, and the *Apologia pauperum*. Daniel suggested that Bonaventure was defending a Franciscan eschatology that saw in Francis the renewal of evangelical perfection and the model of the *vir spiritualis* in the last times. Francis's desire to share in the sufferings of Christ was to be a model for all those who would pass from speculation to love, from the sixth age of knowledge to the seventh age of ecstatic peace.⁶⁵ Daniel's interpretation closely follows the thought of Bonaventure who, in the seventh chapter of the *Itinerarium*, writes:

There he passed over into God in ecstatic contemplation and became an example of perfect contemplation . . . so that through him . . . God might invite all truly spiritual people to this kind of passing over and spiritual ecstasy.⁶⁶

Daniel indicates that Francis's transition to the seventh age of peace is an ecstatic event and one, therefore, that cannot be institutionalized.⁶⁷ Bonaventure himself suggests this when he states:

This is the seraphic order. It seems that Francis belonged to it. . . . This, indeed, is the most difficult, that is, elevation, for the whole body is shaken, and unless there be some consolation of the Holy Spirit, it could not survive. And in these things, the church is consummated. But what this order is to be, or already is, it is hard to know.⁶⁸

He indicates that the seraphic order will consist of those who have attained the level of ecstasy. In the *Hexaëmeron* Bonaventure implies that the seraphic order will include mendicants and lay people, stating, "sometimes a lay person may be more perfect than a religious."⁶⁹ The Franciscan order, standing in the order of the cherubim and at the threshold of the *transitus*, has the mission of bringing about evangelical perfection for all people who wish to imitate Francis and rise through *speculatio* to divine ecstasy.⁷⁰ This view is affirmed by the

⁶⁴ Ibid., 49–55.

⁶⁵ Daniel, "Defender of Eschatology" (n. 3 above), 801–2.

⁶⁶ *Itin.* 7, 3 (V, 312). Trans. Cousins, *Bonaventure*, 112–13.

⁶⁷ E. Randolph Daniel, "St. Bonaventure a Faithful Disciple of St. Francis? An Examination of the Question," in *Bonaventuriana* 1:172–87, esp. 185–86. Daniel's argument stands against that of Ratzinger (*Theology of History*, 50) who claims that to ensure the order's transition to the seventh age, Bonaventure had to create institutional structures.

⁶⁸ *Hex.* 22, 22 (V, 440). Trans. De Vinck, *Six Days of Creation*, 352.

⁶⁹ *Hex.* 22, 23 (V, 441). "Comparatio autem est secundum status, non secundum personas; quia una persona laica aliquando perfectior est quam religiosa."

⁷⁰ Daniel, "St. Bonaventure a Faithful Disciple," 186.

eschatological nature of the *Rule*.⁷¹ From Daniel's perspective, Francis remains the founder of the order, a position supported by Zachary Hayes: "As such, he [Francis] is the exemplar not only for the friars but for all who would embark upon an authentic journey of the spirit into God."⁷²

The notion that the final age is marked by the seraphic order (those who like Francis attain union with the Crucified) indicates that compassionate love is the fulfillment of the final age. In light of the *Itinerarium*, Bonaventure sees the fruit of mystical union as love, and more specifically as cruciform love.⁷³ Just as the cross is the perfect expression of God's love in the Son, so too, the perfect response to God's love is to become like the Son, cruciform in love — this is the goal of contemplative prayer. In the *De triplici via* Bonaventure associates the perfect love of God, compassionate love, with peace, which is the goal of history. He states:

This peace cannot be had without charity. As soon as we acquire charity, all that pertains to perfection becomes easy: acting or suffering, living or dying. We must advance, therefore, in perfect love, for perfect love leads to perfection in all else.⁷⁴

Daniel has rightly noted that for Bonaventure perfect love of God corresponds to the desire for martyrdom.⁷⁵ Like Francis, Bonaventure holds up the desire for martyrdom as a step in the mystical ascent toward union with God. In the *De triplici via* he describes the ascent to God along the paths of purgation, illumination, and union. Accordingly, he describes a hierarchy of love which underscores a desire for martyrdom:

First, our delight should be so well adapted to God that we must be happy to find it in him alone. Second, we must be happy in that we please none but him. Third, we must be happy in that others share his delight with us. . . . In the first, there is gratuitous love; in the second, a love that is due; in the third, a love that is a combination of both. In the first, the world is crucified to man; in the second, man

⁷¹For the eschatological symbolism of the Franciscan *Rule*, see E. Randolph Daniel, "The Desire for Martyrdom: A *Leitmotiv* of St. Bonaventure," *Franciscan Studies* 30 (1972): 86–87; Conrad Harkins, "The Authorship of a Commentary on the Franciscan Rule Published among the Works of Bonaventure," *Franciscan Studies* 29 (1969): 157–248.

⁷²Zachary Hayes, "The Theological Image of St. Francis of Assisi in the Sermons of St. Bonaventure," in *Bonaventuriana* 2:345.

⁷³Hans Peter Heinz, "Dreifaltige Liebe–Gekreuzigte Liebe," *Wissenschaft und Weisheit* 47 (1984): 12–22. Heinz develops Bonaventure's doctrine of cruciform love based on the *De triplici via*. A more detailed discussion of cruciform love is by Bonifatius Strack, *Christusleid im Christenleben. Ein Beitrag zur Theologie des christlichen Lebens nach dem heiligen Bonaventura* (Werl/Westfalen, 1960), 40–150, esp. 40–50.

⁷⁴*De tripl. via* 2, 11 (VIII, 11a). Trans. José de Vinck, "The Triple Way or Love Enkindled," in *St. Bonaventure: Mystical Opuscula* (Paterson, N.J., 1960), 78.

⁷⁵E. Randolph Daniel, *The Franciscan Concept of Mission in the High Middle Ages* (Lexington, Ky., 1975), 50; idem, "Desire for Martyrdom," 74–86.

is crucified to the world; in the third, man is crucified for the sake of the world, since he chooses to die for all in order that all may please God.⁷⁶

Bonaventure identifies the last stage as the level of perfect love. This perfection is attained, he claims, when one finds the heart “longing to die for the salvation of one’s neighbor,” that is, when one is so inflamed by the spirit of Christ that he or she is willing to die not only for Christ but with Christ, with the same intensity of love that Christ manifested on the cross.⁷⁷ This is the goal of union with Christ that forms the opening of the *Lignum vitae*: “With Christ I am nailed to the cross.”⁷⁸ For Bonaventure imitation of, fervent meditation on, ardent prayer about, and contemplation of the crucified humanity of Christ are the necessary steps that lead the spiritual person to the ultimate goal of union with God. The spiritual life must give rise to the desire for martyrdom so that, fired by the longing for death, one may pass over into peace.⁷⁹ Only in this way can the seraphic order, of which Francis is the paradigm, be the true order of *virī spirituales*, fulfilling the age of the New Testament in the union with Christ.⁸⁰

The weaving of mystical union with eschatology underscores the notion that union is not a privilege for religious, nor does it require flight from the world. Rather, it is to be the goal of all spiritual people. The truly spiritual person is one who, like Christ, is willing to lay down his or her life for the neighbor so that “all may be one” (Jn 17:43); this is the mark of ecstatic love. It is the love attained through conformity to and union with Christ, transforming a person into the likeness of Christ and thus into the depths of his compassionate love. Hinrich Stoevesandt has interpreted Bonaventure’s eschatology in its contemplative goal of ecstasy as speculative and passive, declaring it a “utopia of love” and one favored by theologians of hope.⁸¹ His position has been challenged by Paul

⁷⁶ *De tripl. via* 2, 8 (VIII, 9b). Trans. De Vinck, *Triple Way*, 76.

⁷⁷ *Ibid.*

⁷⁸ *Lig. vit.* prol., 1 (VIII, 68). “Christo confixus sum cruci”; cf. Gal. 2:20 RSV.

⁷⁹ Daniel, *Concept of Mission*, 51.

⁸⁰ *Hex.* 22, 6 (V, 438). Bonaventure specifically identifies the seraphic order of *virī spirituales* with the apostolic order of the New Testament stating that, “the apostolic order is conformed to Christ.” This is a clear affirmation of the endurance of the New Testament against those who proclaimed that the age of *virī spirituales* ushered in a new eternal testament (*evangelium aeternum*). The foremost proponent of the eternal testament was Gerard of Borgo San Donnino who, in 1254, published his *Introductorius in evangelium aeternum*, claiming that the Franciscan order, in light of its apocalyptic founder, would triumph in the final age. The eternal testament, the testament of the Spirit, would supersede the Old Testament and New Testament since it was given by the Holy Spirit to Francis. Thus, the New Testament and the clergy would be supplanted by the eternal testament and its bearers. Gerard’s work was condemned by Pope Alexander IV in 1255. See Daniel, *Concept of Mission*, 79; McGinn, “Abbot and the Doctors” (n. 15 above), 44; Reeves, *Influence of Prophecy* (n. 20 above), 176–77.

⁸¹ Hinrich Stoevesandt, *Die letzten Dinge in der Theologie Bonaventuras* (Zurich, 1969), 65–71. Stoevesandt compares Bonaventure’s eschatology with the “theology of hope” of the contemporary theologian, Jürgen Moltmann. He discovers a similarity between them, stating that

Vigneaux, based on Bonaventure's doctrine of Christocentricity.⁸² Vigneaux's analysis, however, is philosophical and leaves out the essential aspect of mystical union. In the *Legenda maior* Bonaventure indicates that ecstatic union with the Crucified does not lead to passive withdrawal from the world, but rather leads one into the heart of the world. In the *De triplici via* he describes perfect love as ascending and descending: ascending to God and descending to neighbor.⁸³ In the *Breviloquium* he affirms that this is how Christ himself manifested perfect love.⁸⁴ He describes Francis, immediately after the stigmata, "burning with a seraphic love of God for the salvation of all people" and returning to the ministry to lepers, which he undertook at the beginning of his conversion.⁸⁵ Thus Bonaventure holds that union with God is to be visibly expressed as cruciform love and this love is to mark the final age of peace. Bonaventure's notion of the final age of peace as one contingent on mystical union with Christ distinguishes him from Joachim, for whom the final age remains a prophetic anticipation of the future. For the Seraphic Doctor, the concept of union means that the historical process, conditioned by one's relationship with Christ, encompasses the final age. The final age is neither a future state nor a future *ordo*, as Joachim maintained, but is already present, since Francis achieved it. The identification of one who has achieved the final age is the visible expression of cruciform love.

THE FINAL AGE OF PEACE AND THE HUMANITY OF CHRIST

The most distinguishing mark of Bonaventure's eschatology is that the final age is brought about by union with Christ. Daniel had identified the features of Bonaventure's eschatology that correspond to Joachim's, suggesting that Bonaventure's doctrine is indebted to Joachim. The similarity between the two, according to Daniel, rests not only on the patterns of history they present, but also on the notion that the final age belongs to Christ.⁸⁶ Among scholars of Joachimism, Daniel's insight on the final age, as one belonging to Christ, is new. Prior to Daniel, scholars interpreted Joachim's third *status* as the age of the Spirit, supplanting the age of the Son.⁸⁷ After the age of the Father, which

both are utopic: for Moltmann the goal of the eschaton is Christian hope, for Bonaventure it is Christian love. Moreover, Stoevesandt (p. 67) claims that the innerhistorical final age for Bonaventure is speculative and passive, not active.

⁸²Paul Vigneaux, "Condition historique de la pensée de saint Bonaventure: Christocentrisme, eschatologie et situation de la culture philosophique," *Miscellanea Francescana* 75 (1975): 422–27.

⁸³*De tripl. via* 2, 5–8 (VIII, 9); *LM* 8, 1 (EM, 64); *LM* 13, 1 (EM, 106).

⁸⁴*Brev.* 4, 9 (V, 249–50).

⁸⁵*LM* 14, 1 (EM, 115).

⁸⁶Daniel, "Bonaventure's Debt to Joachim" (n. 25 above), 68–70.

⁸⁷Reeves, "Dante and the Prophetic View of History" (n. 14 above), 54; Crocco, *Giacchino da Fiore* (n. 14 above), 91–114; Ratzinger, *Theology of History* (n. 14 above), 109–18.

belonged to the laity, would come the age of the Son belonging to the clergy, and after this age would come the age of the Holy Spirit belonging to the monks.⁸⁸ The final age, therefore, would be the age of the Holy Spirit. This led Ratzinger to conclude that Bonaventure ultimately rejected Joachim, because for him Christ was only a turning point in history.⁸⁹ Daniel has argued that the final age is not one that belongs uniquely to the Spirit but rather is a realization of the mystical body of Christ. The basis of his argument is the double procession of the Holy Spirit: in the Old Testament the Spirit proceeds from the Father, in the New Testament he proceeds from the Father and Son.⁹⁰ Daniel states that Joachim did not envision three successive orders (laity, clergy, monks) in three successive ages (Father, Son, Spirit) but rather the three orders were to evolve into a single unity:

He believed that God viewed the three orders as one man made of flesh, blood, and the breath of life. Joachim defined the goal by citing Paul. The three orders must evolve until they become the image and likeness of the Trinity so that at last all shall come together in the unity of the faith, into mature manhood according to the measure of the fullness of Christ.⁹¹

According to Reeves, Joachim perceived the work of the Trinity throughout history, but the work of the Spirit was the culmination of history in the third *status*. She maintains that he envisaged a *new* stage of history.⁹² Daniel, however, interprets Joachim's trinitarian scheme as a movement toward the mystical body of Christ, thus preempting any new stage in history. He states:

Joachim is able to ascribe the third *status* to the Holy Spirit and at the same time envision it as the realization of the mystical body of Christ, because for him the

⁸⁸On earlier views see Bloomfield, "Critical Survey" (n. 15 above), 260–71.

⁸⁹Ratzinger, *Theology of History*, 118. Ratzinger claims that Bonaventure ultimately rejected Joachim's *prima diffinitio* because it denied Christ as center. However, he also acknowledges Joachim's influence on Bonaventure particularly with regard to historical schemes (p. 48). David Burr ("Bonaventure, Olivi and Franciscan Eschatology," *Collectanea Franciscana* 53 [1983]: 28) states that Bonaventure's trinitarian structure of history "implies both yes and no to Joachim." Daniel ("Debt to Joachim," 70) claims that Bonaventure did not reject the abbot "but restudied him," a position also held by McGinn ("Abbot and the Doctors," 43). Reeves's position is more ambivalent. She states that "Bonaventure was a Joachimite *malgré lui* (*Influence of Prophecy*, 181), but elsewhere maintains uncertainty as to whether or not Bonaventure "in his doctrine of history was a conscious adapter of the Joachimist expectation" ("Originality of Joachim," 302).

⁹⁰Daniel, "Double Procession of the Holy Spirit" (n. 13 above), 472. Daniel bases his argument on Joachim's text from the *Liber de concordia* (bk. 2, tr. 1, ch. 8, fol. 9vb.): "Quia vero unus est Pater a quo procedunt Filius et Spiritus Sanctus, unus Spiritus qui a Patre simul procedit et Filio, duo qui procedunt ab uno Patre, recte primus status ascribitur Patri, secundus soli Filio, tertius communis Filio et Spiritui Sancto."

⁹¹Daniel, "Double Procession," 475; cf. Eph. 4:13 RSV.

⁹²Reeves, "Originality of Joachim" (n. 5 above), 293; eadem, *Joachim and the Prophetic Future* (n. 7 above), 6.

third *status* is the historical expression of the procession of the Holy Spirit from the Son.⁹³

Since the Spirit is sent by Christ to fulfill his work, the goal of the final age is to realize the body of Christ. The *pleroma* is the unity of the diverse, the inclusion of all orders in the one body of Christ, which is manifested in the image of the Trinity.⁹⁴ Deborah Workman notes that Daniel's argument highlights the fullness of Christ as a predominant aspect of life in the third *status*: an age, she states, that has too frequently been identified only with the power of the Holy Spirit.⁹⁵

Although the notion of the final age as the mystical body of Christ draws Joachim's thought closer to Bonaventure's, I suggest that the image that governs the historical process maintains a distance between them. While Joachim portrays history as a process forming an image of the Trinity, Bonaventure maintains that history follows the image of Christ the center. The Son is the perfect image of the Father and humans are created as images of God in that they are created as images of the Son, the one true Image. Indeed, it is precisely the notion of the Son as the perfect image of the Father that Bonaventure uses to explicate, from the point of congruency, the Incarnation of the second person of the Trinity.⁹⁶ To be an image of the Son, as Francis maintained, is to be conformed to him in both body and spirit.⁹⁷

In the *Hexaëmeron*, Bonaventure indicates that conformity to Christ in body and spirit is the hallmark of the *virī spirituales* of the final age. In *Hex.* 20, 15 he states that in the final age "there will be a consummation of those sufferings of Christ which he now bears in his [mystical] body."⁹⁸ Similarly, in *Hex.* 22, 23 he states: "This order will not flourish unless Christ appears and suffers in his mystical body."⁹⁹ The idea of Christ "appearing and suffering" conjures up

⁹³Daniel, "Double Procession," 476.

⁹⁴*Ibid.*, 475.

⁹⁵Workman, "Spirit Clothed in Flesh" (n. 20 above), 195; cf. Crocco (*Gioacchino da Fiore*, 114) who also identifies the third age as the mystical body of Christ but one that is marked by the power of the Spirit and not the unity of orders.

⁹⁶*III Sent.* d. 1, a. 2, q. 3, resp. (III, 29–30); cf. Zachary Hayes, introduction to *Saint Bonaventure's Disputed Questions on the Mystery of the Trinity* (St. Bonaventure, 1979), 32. Hayes notes that by being molded into the image of the Son, one enters into the Son's relationship with the Father and Spirit. By becoming Christ-like the human person is conformed to the Trinity.

⁹⁷Francis of Assisi, *Admonition 5. Saint François d'Assise. Documents, écrits et premières biographies*, ed. Théophile Desbonnets (Paris, 1968), 98.

⁹⁸*Hex.* 20, 15 (V, 428). "Quando consummabuntur passionēs Christi, quas modo corpus Christi patitur."

⁹⁹*Hex.* 22, 23 (V, 441). "Iste ordo non florebit, nisi Christus appareat et patiat in corpore suo mystico."

the stigmata, implying that the seraphic order will be those who are conformed to Christ not only in the spirit but in the flesh as well. That Bonaventure proposes the seraphic order as the *virī spirituales* of the final age rests on the idea that Francis is the model of that age *par excellence*, and that the stigmata are the signs of having attained the seventh age of peace.¹⁰⁰ The stigmata signify that Francis was transformed into the true image of Christ, since he was conformed in both body and spirit, being “inwardly inflamed” and “outwardly marked.”¹⁰¹ This is how Bonaventure describes Francis after the La Verna experience:

When the true love of Christ had transformed his lover into his image . . . the angelic man came down from the mountain bearing with him the image of the Crucified . . . engraved in the members of his body by the finger of the living God.¹⁰²

Ecstatic union with Christ, according to the Seraphic Doctor, has its visible expression, and he envisions that, in the final stage, there will be spiritual people who, like Francis, are conformed inwardly and outwardly to the crucified Christ: inwardly through the fire of the Holy Spirit, outwardly by bearing a visible sign of union with Christ.

He said that this apparition of the seraph to blessed Francis, which was both expressive and impressed, showed that this order was to correspond to this one (the seraph), but that he (Francis) was to attain it through hardships.¹⁰³

The inward-outward expression of union with Christ underscores Bonaventure’s concept of image, and of the mystical body of Christ; Christ appears mystically in that he appears in his own image, that is, in each person created in the image of the Son. One who, like Francis, is conformed to Christ the image is a fully actualized person — that is, there is perfect coherence between spirit and flesh: what appears to be in the flesh is what a person is in spirit and truth.

Bonaventure also indicates that the final age will be marked by the image of the crucified Christ when he describes the conformity of the church militant to the church triumphant.¹⁰⁴ This is a mystical reference to the appearance of Christ in his mystical body, the time when the prophecy of Ezekiel (40:3) will be fulfilled. As he states:

The city will come down from heaven, not that city which is above, but the one that is below, that is, the church militant . . . then there will be a building of the city and a restoration [of it] as it was in the beginning. And then there shall be peace.¹⁰⁵

¹⁰⁰ *LM* 13, 10 (EM, 108).

¹⁰¹ *Ibid.*

¹⁰² *LM* 13, 5 (EM, 109). Trans. Cousins, *Bonaventure*, 307.

¹⁰³ *Hex.* 22, 22 (V, 441). Trans. De Vinck, *Six Days of Creation*, 352.

¹⁰⁴ *Hex.* 16, 30 (V, 408).

¹⁰⁵ *Hex.* 16, 31 (V, 408). Trans. De Vinck, *Six Days of Creation*, 249–50.

Bonaventure identifies the "city coming down from heaven" as the incarnate Word, the "assumed humanity."¹⁰⁶ He then defines the four sides of the city: "There is a marvelous origin in the nativity, a marvelous fall in the crucifixion, a marvelous ascent in the resurrection and ascension and [there will be] a marvelous return at the time of judgment."¹⁰⁷ The four sides of the city that Bonaventure describes in the *Hexaëmeron* are part of the seven features of the humanity of Christ that he describes in the *Breviloquium*: "The humanity of Christ must be seen as conceived of the Holy Spirit, born of the Virgin, suffering on the cross, descending into hell, rising from the dead, ascending into heaven, and coming at the final judgment."¹⁰⁸

The appearance of the crucified humanity of Christ in the final age, therefore, corresponds to the role in that age of the seraphic order. The basis of this order is union with the Crucified, which is to be expressed both inwardly and outwardly. Francis attained the seraphic order because he was perfectly conformed to Christ. As one imprinted with the likeness of Christ,¹⁰⁹ Francis became the most sublime image of Christ, an image engraved by the power of the Spirit and the burning love of God, as Bonaventure writes: "Now fixed with Christ to the cross in both body and spirit, Francis . . . burned with a seraphic love of God."¹¹⁰ In light of this image, the Seraphic Doctor views the final age as one marked by the humanity of Christ. The sign of the *alter Christus*,¹¹¹ the ecstatic who is so united to the Crucified that he or she becomes crucified, is the glory of the final age. The church of contemplatives, the seraphic order, will be the true appearance of the crucified Christ in his mystical body,¹¹² which will be the manifestation of his glory.¹¹³ The appearance of Christ in the final age means the realization of the kingdom; unity in the body of Christ, who is in union with the Father, will bring all those united to him into the oneness of the Father and the Son. The Franciscan concept of image, therefore, in Bonaventure's writings undergirds his understanding of the seraphic order, the *virī spirituales* of the

¹⁰⁶ *Hex.* 23, 7 (V, 446).

¹⁰⁷ *Ibid.*

¹⁰⁸ *Brev.* 5, 7 (V, 261a). Trans. De Vinck, *Breviloquium*, 209.

¹⁰⁹ *LM* 14, 4 (EM, 118). Trans. Cousins, *Bonaventure*, 318.

¹¹⁰ *LM* 14, 1 (EM, 115). Trans. Cousins, *Bonaventure*, 315.

¹¹¹ Throughout Bonaventure's *Legenda maior* there are numerous examples of Francis as an *alter Christus*: for example, Francis's retreat to lonely places to pray (*LM* 10, 3); his fasting in solitude for forty days (*LM* 13, 1); his manner of preaching (*LM* 12, 12), healing (*LM* 13, 6–7), and working miracles (*LM* 7–13); cf. Haase ("Bonaventure's *Legenda Maior*," 334), who provides a longer list but without specific references to the text. See also Raoul Manselli, "San Bonaventura e la storia francescana," in 1274, *Année Charnière: Mutations et continuités* (Paris, 1977), 863–72. Manselli associates Francis, the angel of true peace, with the image of *alter Christus*.

¹¹² *Hex.* 22, 23 (V, 441).

¹¹³ *Lig. vit.* 44 (VIII, 84).

final age, and indicates that this age will be marked by the humanity of Christ. Those who are in union with Christ will visibly express this union, and, like Francis, will be other Christs.

Daniel has argued that Bonaventure's Christocentric eschatology resembles Joachim's insofar as both foresee the final age as one belonging to Christ. He states that Joachim is able to ascribe the third *status* to the Holy Spirit and, at the same time, envision it as the realization of the mystical body of Christ because the third *status* is the historical expression of the Holy Spirit's procession not only from the Father but from the Son.¹¹⁴ The final age is the image of the Trinity because it is the age of unity and diversity, just as the Trinity is three persons in one substance. The significance of Daniel's interpretation is that it illuminates Joachim's theology of history not as a succession of orders (that is, laity, clergy, and monks) but rather as a unity of orders in the final age. Although he argues convincingly of Joachim's final age as the age of the mystical body of Christ, it is ultimately the age of the Spirit. As a former Cistercian, Joachim betrays a Bernardine understanding of the Incarnation: the carnal love of Christ is to lead to the spiritual love of God, and this constitutes the age of the Son. In the *Liber de concordia*, Joachim states:

The Spirit was revealed first to Mary, then at the baptism of Christ, next to those baptized in Christ, and lastly at Pentecost, but these "children" or "little ones" were not prepared to absorb the *spiritualis intellectus*. The principal role, therefore, had to belong to the visible Christ who humbled himself by becoming man.¹¹⁵

The procession of the Holy Spirit from the Son explains Joachim's insistence on the *plenitudo Christi* as the ultimate achievement of the final age. But this mystical body is in the Augustinian sense of *totus Christus*, that is, the one collective body made of flesh, blood, and the breath of life, and this for Joachim is the three orders united in the one Spirit. Although Daniel elucidates Joachim's concept of the mystical body of Christ, he acknowledges that it is the work of the Spirit:

Joachim's Christology is both kenotic and pleromatic. In Jesus, Christ has emptied himself of his glory by assuming human flesh in order to reveal himself to carnal men who like spiritual infants could only perceive him in tangible form. The ultimate goal of redemptive history is the realization of the mystical body of Christ, the achievement of which is the work of the Holy Spirit.¹¹⁶

¹¹⁴Daniel, "Double Procession" (n. 13 above), 477.

¹¹⁵Joachim of Fiore, *Liber de concordia*, bk. 2, tr. 1, ch. 8, fol. 17 vb. Trans. Daniel, "Double Procession," 474.

¹¹⁶Daniel, "Debt to Joachim" (n. 25 above), 68.

Daniel suggests that Joachim's final age of Christ is much closer to Bonaventure's Christocentric final age than has previously been understood,¹¹⁷ but Reeves maintains a "niggling doubt."¹¹⁸ In support of Reeves's position, I maintain that while Joachim and Bonaventure acknowledge the powerful work of the Spirit in this age, producing *virī spirituales* and giving rise to the mystical body of Christ, the character of this mystical body, based on the concept of image, distinguishes the Cistercian prophet from the Franciscan mystic. For Joachim, the image of the Trinity means the unity of diverse orders in the unity of the Spirit. For Bonaventure, the image of the Son means an inward and outward expression of conformity to Christ. In light of Francis, Bonaventure presents an eschatology that is fundamentally mystical, since the path to peace is union with the Crucified. This imparts a distinctly Franciscan feature to his doctrine, distinguishing him from the Calabrian abbot. Joachim does not anticipate union with the Crucified as the mark of the third *status*, nor does he expect in that *status* physical expression of the mystical body of Christ; rather, the body's reality will be entirely spiritual. In contrast, Bonaventure's conception of a seraphic order transformed in the image of Christ implies that the final age will be marked by the humanity of Christ, suffering and glorified.

In Bonaventure's Franciscan eschatology, the transition from the sixth age to the seventh age means a movement toward Christ the center. Just as Christ in his humanity has reconciled the world to the Father, so, too, those who attain the level of union with Christ will enable the historical process to realize its destiny — in Christ, everything will transcend this process and pass over to the Father. It is the Spirit who both unites the soul inwardly to Christ and visibly expresses this union in the members of the Church conformed to Christ. At the level of mystical union, the nuptial uniting of God with the world is perfect and complete: the Spirit can penetrate no further. The Spirit bears witness to the humanity of Christ, since all those united to Christ in the Spirit will become like Christ, each an *alter Christus*. Bonaventure's Christocentric vision of the final age shows that in union with Christ the soul is brought into the life of God, and at the same time, into the final stage of peace. The lines of heaven and earth are drawn together in the one center, in whom everything returns to its origin.

¹¹⁷Ibid., 69–70. Daniel states: "No theologian could describe Joachim's theology of history as Christocentric in the same sense [as Bonaventure's] but the relationship between the Son and the Holy Spirit in the *secunda diffinitio* points in a similar direction."

¹¹⁸Reeves, "Originality of Joachim" (n. 5 above), 301. Reeves's "doubt" becomes a firm denial in McGinn ("The Significance of Bonaventure's Theology of History," *Journal of Religion* 58 [1978]: 77) who clearly states that Joachim's view of history is not Christocentric. This conclusion is based on the notion of Christ as a turning point in history ("the person of Christ tends to become just another element of comparison rather than the primary analogate, the middle point that explains all.") He does not entertain the idea of the double procession of the Holy Spirit.

CONCLUSION

Joachim of Fiore's prophetic vision profoundly influenced later medieval eschatology and left its imprint on Franciscan theology. Although Bonaventure was influenced by some of Joachim's ideas, he held a unique Franciscan eschatology, aptly described as "Franciscan" because the order's founder himself had provided the model of the final age of peace. Both Joachim and Bonaventure maintain that the final age is intramundane and characterized by contemplative peace; however, Bonaventure considers mystical union the key to entering the final age. Although the blueprint of Bonaventure's thought is laid down in his *Itinerarium*, he presents his full eschatological vision of Christocentricity and mystical union in his lectures on the *Hexaëmeron*. In light of Francis, he conceives of the final age as one not in the future but already taking place: the stigmatized Francis indicates that the final age is now. The immediacy of the final age means that for those who, like Francis, are conformed to the Crucified and living in the spirit of cruciform love, it is possible to live in the final age. The immediacy of the final age and the mark of it as cruciform love are not part of Joachim's thought. Rather, for the abbot, the final age is to take place in the future, and will be characterized by a distinct order of contemplative people.

The underlying difference between Joachim and Bonaventure is reflected in the concept of image: whereas Joachim holds up the image of the Trinity, Bonaventure holds up the image of the Son. The final age for Joachim, in its trinitarian image, is the glorified mystical body of Christ; for Bonaventure, the image of the final age is the suffering humanity of Christ. These two distinct images characterizing the final age may reflect the fact that the fundamental difference between Joachim and Bonaventure is rooted in their understanding of the Trinity itself. Whereas Joachim holds to a western, Augustinian conception of the Trinity, based on a single divine mystery constituted by interpersonal relationships, Bonaventure follows the more Greek approach to the Trinity, which emphasizes the primacy of the Father as source and the dynamic of the self-diffusive good. Consequently, Joachim's view of history is a multi-dimensional pattern of relationships that reaches its consummation in perfect unity-in-diversity, just as the Trinity is one God in the three divine persons, coequal and coeternal. Bonaventure's view of history, on the other hand, is oriented to Christ the center. Just as the Word is the center of the Trinity, mediating between the Father and the Spirit, so too, Christ is the center of emanation and return in creation. There is no other path to the Father, Bonaventure states, than through the burning love of the Crucified.¹¹⁹ The two distinct theologies of the Trinity, therefore, may give rise to two distinct eschatologies, one prophetic in nature and trinitarian in

¹¹⁹ *Itin.* prol., 3 (V, 297). "Via autem non est nisi per ardentissimum amorem Crucifixi."

image, the other mystical in nature and Christoformic in image. That Bonaventure recognizes Joachim yet follows a different path to the final age may reflect the fact that he had a personal model to follow, in Francis, whereas Joachim did not.

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